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**Subject:** Freedom of expression: a collective reflection to be carried out

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(This is a Google-translate English version of the French original.)

## MESSAGE

DANIEL JUTRAS, RECTOR

# Freedom of expression: a collective reflection to be carried out

*Wednesday, October 21, 2020*

Dear members of the university community,

For the past few weeks, the university has been in turmoil. One is concerned about his values, the vitality of his ideal of freedom and his ability to educate and to think about the world in a plural way. His courage and benevolence are in turn assessed. We accuse her, we judge her, we sentence her. The protagonists agitate, confront and insult each other. The media are heating up, the tweets are streaming and the political actors are rebelling. Once again, some propose to supervise the university, to force it to rules, to impose ways of doing things that would threaten what it has most precious: its autonomy.

The debate over freedom of expression at the university and respect for the dignity of its individuals and communities has been ensted in unambitized clashes. It has become difficult to approach these issues from the serene perspective expected of academics. Aware of my own identity and perspective as well as the privileges it confers on me, I strive to observe, listen, inform myself, gather the facts, weigh the issues, question my own biases and take a critical and reflective look at the solutions that are proposed to me.

I would like to invite you to follow me in this process, which I believe is a hallmark of university life. The time has come for the University of Montreal to engage in a free, open, respectful and pluralistic conversation about the meaning of its core values of freedom of expression, free speech, critical thinking, welcoming otherness and respect for dignity. How do we define them collectively? How do we give them substance in our teaching, research and socialization practices on our campuses? Over the next few weeks, months, I will invite our community to reflect on these issues that affect us all. I intend to begin this conversation as soon as the University Assembly is on November 2.

In recent days, I have been invited to take a position in the current debate on several occasions. I'm hesitant to do that. I have convictions, of course. They belong to me. In stating them, I am not speaking for the University. But I am not fooled: my status as rector undeniably gives them a scope that exceeds my person. Aware of this risk, I nevertheless ask today the first words of a conversation that I wish to start and nurture with you in the near future.

I would like to start by addressing the issues that concern us from my experience as a teacher. As such, it seems clear to me that my responsibility begins with building a relationship of trust with the students who share the classroom. Through me, and others, they access the world of ideas. In the classroom, I remain the one who sets the parameters of the conversation and sets the conditions for the possibility of a scientific, critical and reflexive discourse. I must inspire, through my own behaviour, the conduct of free debate, that is, the expression of disagreements and the slow but sure acquisition of a shared understanding of the issues studied. I am primarily responsible for the respect that must be established between all of us and all of us.

My classroom, like the University, is first and foremost a place of freedom. I must be able to express any proposal, any idea that I am able to defend rationally. I agree, in turn, to expose them to the criticism of all those who participate with me in the conversation. None is excluded in principle and it is even the condition of the quest for truth as I see it. In my class, ideological pluralism remains the first rule of

the game.

The second, just as important, is respect for the dignity of each other. No one has the right to insult, invective or humiliate another interlocutor. Intentional insults are banned at the outset, but each must also be attentive to the unforeseen, sometimes unsuspected, effect of their own discourse on others. Words can rekindle deep wounds, cause individual trajectories to capsize. They sometimes carry the weight of systemic racism, sexism or discrimination, which are still present in our institutions. But in my class, as in the University, each person is responsible for his words and chooses them in a way that supports mutual trust between us.

I consider university speech to be free. No words are forbidden in the context of a search for truth and righteousness. No dogma, religious or secular, can be subtracted from this quest. This freedom, which excludes Manichaeism and absolutism, is the heart of our university life. No one can deprive me of it. But it must not overshadow my individual responsibility, as an actor in the world of higher education, to reflect on my pedagogical practices. Above all, this freedom does not absolve anyone, students or teachers, of the responsibility to preserve the conditions of serenity and dignity of our debates.

This, summarily stated, is the reaction to the controversies of the past few weeks. I hope that other voices will be heard in the collective reflection on freedom of expression that we will soon begin at the University of Montreal.

Daniel Jutras  
Rector

